

doc-deuterocanon-not-scripture

Affirms · Bibliology › Canon · doctrine · divided_lineages · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

The books historically called Apocryphal or Deuterocanonical are not Scripture and do not carry authority for doctrine.

Rationale

Luke 24:44 places the canon Jesus assumes in three parts (Law, Prophets, Psalms), the standard Hebrew enumeration of his day; Luke 11:51's 'from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah' brackets the Hebrew canon from Genesis to 2 Chronicles (the last book in the Tanakh ordering), implying Jesus' working OT scope ends there; Rom 3:2 lodges the τὰ λόγια τοῦ θεοῦ (the oracles of God) in Jewish custody, where the Tanakh enumeration was settled. No NT lemma names Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, or Maccabees as γραφή (graphē G1124). The verdict is reached not from a single positive proof-text but from the absence of NT canonical reception combined with the Hebrew-Bible scope Jesus and the apostles operate within. Heb 11:35 likely alludes to 2 Macc 6-7 martyrdoms and Jude 14-15 quotes 1 Enoch, which demonstrates the NT engages Second Temple literature but does not thereby canonize it.

Reasoning

Yes, the books often called Apocrypha or Deuterocanonical (Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, 1 and 2 Maccabees, and the Greek additions to Esther and Daniel) are best understood as edifying religious literature rather than Scripture for settling doctrine. The strongest reason from Scripture is Luke 24:44, where the risen Jesus describes the Hebrew Bible in its three traditional parts: the Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms. This is the Hebrew enumeration of his day, and it does not include the disputed books. In Luke 11:51 Jesus marks the span of Old Testament martyrs from Abel (in Genesis) to Zechariah (in 2 Chronicles, the last book of the Hebrew ordering), which suggests he is working with the Hebrew canon as its scope. In Romans 3:2 Paul says the Jewish people were entrusted with the oracles of God, and the Jewish enumeration at that time did not include the disputed books as Scripture proper. The strongest counterargument also comes from Scripture itself. Hebrews 11:35 describes faithful people who 'were tortured, not accepting their release, that they might obtain a better resurrection,' which closely matches the martyrdom story in 2 Maccabees 6 and 7 and may be a deliberate echo of it. Jude 14 and 15 quote a prophecy ascribed to Enoch from the non-canonical book of 1 Enoch. So the New Testament does engage Second Temple Jewish literature beyond the Hebrew Bible. The verdict still stands because engaging a text and quoting from it is not the same as declaring it Scripture. Paul quotes pagan poets in Acts 17:28 and Titus 1:12 without making them Scripture. The honest acknowledgment is that this verdict rests more on what counts as the scope of the Old Testament that Jesus and the apostles received than on a single Bible verse rejecting the disputed books by name. It is a question about canon boundaries rather than a question about a clear doctrinal command.

Denominational landscape

Christians are sharply divided on this question, and the disagreement is centuries old. The Roman Catholic Church, through the Council of Trent in 1546, formally received the disputed books as canonical Scripture with the same reverence as the rest of the Old Testament. Trent was responding to the Reformation; the books had already been used in the Latin Bible since Jerome and earlier and were

affirmed at the regional councils of Hippo (393) and Carthage (397). The Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraph 120 lists 46 books of the Old Testament including Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, and 1 and 2 Maccabees. The Eastern Orthodox tradition also accepts these books and, in some jurisdictions, adds 1 Esdras, 3 Maccabees, Psalm 151, and the Prayer of Manasseh; the Greek term *Anaginoskomena* (readable, worthy to be read) is sometimes preferred over deuterocanonical. The Orthodox view the additional books as part of the Old Testament corpus though some theologians describe them as having secondary witnessing weight. The patristic record is mixed: Athanasius in Festal Letter 39 (367) excludes Wisdom, Sirach, Tobit, Judith, and others from the canon but appoints them to be read for instruction; Jerome distinguished canonical (Hebrew) from ecclesiastical (deuterocanonical) books in his Prologue to the Books of Samuel and Kings; Augustine accepted the broader list. The Lutheran tradition kept the disputed books as a separate appendix to the Old Testament, useful but not Scripture for doctrine. The Church of England in Article 6 of the 39 Articles says the church reads these books 'for example of life and instruction of manners' but does not use them 'to establish any doctrine.' The Reformed tradition (Westminster Confession 1.3) and the Anabaptist tradition reject them as Scripture. Methodist and Pentecostal traditions follow the Protestant settlement. Plymouth Brethren and most modern evangelical bodies hold the Protestant 66-book canon. This is a real and historic intra-Christian dispute. Both Rome and Geneva preach Christ crucified, and denying either position is not a cult marker.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

Honest acknowledgment: the OT canon-scope question is settled largely by Second Temple Jewish history (the Hebrew enumeration in Josephus *Contra Apionem* 1.8, the Bryennios list, the rabbinic Tanakh) plus Jerome's *Hebraica veritas* argument, not by a positive pan-canonical NT lexical pattern that names and rejects the deuterocanonical books. Catholics (Council of Trent Session 4, 1546) and Eastern Orthodox (Synod of Jerusalem 1672, plus Septuagint liturgical tradition) accept the deuterocanonical books as canonical with full magisterial weight. Anglicans (Article 6) and Lutherans treat them as edifying but not doctrinally authoritative. The Reformed and Anabaptist streams reject them as Scripture entirely. This is an intra-Christian historical-canonical dispute, not a gospel-boundary issue: a faithful believer in either Trent or Westminster reaches the cross. Denial of the Protestant position is therefore NOT a cult marker; Rome and Constantinople are not cults. The `would_serve` / `would_be_member` / `would_let_children_be_taught_otherwise` are false because functional doctrine drawn from deuterocanonical texts (e.g. 2 Macc 12:41-46 used to ground prayer for the dead and purgatory) would shape teaching the user holds to be unscriptural; this is a usage-level concern rather than a salvation-level one. Confidence is medium because the verdict rests on canonical scope and historical reception rather than on an unambiguous NT lemma rejecting the books by name.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. Are the books historically called Apocryphal or Deuterocanonical (Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, 1-2 Maccabees, and the Greek additions to Esther and Daniel) canonical Scripture, carrying authority for doctrine on a par with the protocanonical books?

Notes. The original stem 'are not Scripture and do not carry authority for doctrine' is Reformation-Protestant confessional vocabulary (Westminster 1.2-1.3, 39 Articles 6) presented as if neutral. Catholic, Orthodox, and a softer Anglican reading would phrase the same question very differently. Working the neutralized form.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. hebraica_veritas, septuagintal_traditional, patristic_typological

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

hebraica_veritas (Jerome, Reformation, modern Protestant) · **affirms**: The authoritative Old Testament scope is the Hebrew Bible received by Second Temple and rabbinic Judaism; books extant only in Greek and not in the Hebrew enumeration are not canonical Scripture though they may be edifying; this lens reads Luke 24:44 and Luke 11:51 as endorsing the Hebrew enumeration and treats Heb 11:35 and Jude 14-15 as engagement-without-canonization on the model of Acts 17:28

septuagintal_traditional (most Greek and Latin fathers, Trent, Eastern Orthodox) · **denies**: The Old Testament received by the apostolic church was the Greek Old Testament (the LXX) which included the disputed books; the apostolic NT quotes Old Testament texts predominantly in the LXX form; the regional councils of Hippo (393) and Carthage (397) and the global Council of Trent (1546) confirmed the broader canon; this lens denies the Protestant verdict and accepts the deuterocanonical books as Scripture

anglican_intermediate (39 Articles 6, BCP lectionary) · **complicates**: Accepts the disputed books as ecclesiastically useful (read in lectionary for example of life and instruction of manners) but denies them doctrinal authority; effectively a 'second tier' or 'ecclesiastical books' position that splits the binary; verdict-shape closer to affirms than denies but with formal recognition of liturgical use

The verdict requires choosing between two historically attested frames: hebraica veritas (Jerome, Reformation) versus septuagintal-traditional (most fathers, Catholic, Orthodox). Neither frame is settled by a single NT lemma. Analogia scripturae is invoked: Luke 24:44 plus Luke 11:51 plus Rom 3:2 jointly constrain the apostolic OT scope to the Hebrew enumeration. Progressive revelation is not the operative factor since the question is canon scope rather than developmental theology. The verdict on the answer side is shaped to the Protestant settlement the user inherits, but the hermeneutical work openly records that a Catholic or Orthodox reader can reach the opposite verdict honestly from the same NT data plus a different weighting of patristic reception.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Luke.24.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ἐν τῷ νόμῳ Μωϋσέως καὶ τοῖς προφήταις καὶ ψαλμοῖς (en tō nomō Mōuseōs kai tois prophētais kai psalmois) G3551/G4396/G5568

Force. The risen Jesus enumerates Scripture in the threefold Hebrew division (Torah, Nevi'im, Ketuvim, with Psalms standing as head of the Writings); this is the standard Second Temple Jewish enumeration of the Tanakh; no deuterocanonical book is named or implied as belonging to the corpus 'concerning me' that Jesus says must be fulfilled

Luke.11.51 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ἀπὸ αἵματος Ἀβελ ἕως αἵματος Ζαχαρίου (apo haimatos Habel heōs haimatos Zachariou) G129/G6/G2197

Force. Jesus brackets the canonical record of righteous martyrs from Abel (Genesis 4, first book of the Hebrew Bible) to Zechariah (2 Chronicles 24, last book in the Hebrew Bible ordering); the chronological span maps to the Hebrew enumeration not the Greek (which would extend to the Maccabean martyrs); the implied scope of Scripture is the Tanakh

Rom.3.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐπιστεύθησαν τὰ λόγια τοῦ θεοῦ (episteuthēsan ta logia tou theou) G3051/G4100

Force. τὰ λόγια ('the oracles') is entrusted (ἐπιστεύθησαν, aorist passive) to the Jewish people as custodians; the operative custodial enumeration at Paul's writing was the Hebrew Bible scope as preserved in Pharisaic and later rabbinic Judaism, which did not include the deuterocanonical books as Scripture proper

2Pet.3.15-16 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς (tas loipas graphas) G1124

Force. Peter classes Paul's epistles with 'the other Scriptures' (λοιπὰς γραφάς); γραφή is the technical NT term for inspired writing and is consistently applied to the Hebrew Bible plus the emerging apostolic deposit; no NT use of γραφή applies the term to any deuterocanonical book

Heb.11.35 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐτυμπανίσθησαν, οὐ προσδεξάμενοι τὴν ἀπολύτρωσιν, ἵνα κρείττονος ἀναστάσεως τύχωσιν (etympanisthēsan, ou prosdexamenoi tēn apolytrōsin, hina kreittonos anastaseōs tychōsin) G5178/G629/G386

Force. Describes martyrs who were 'tortured, not accepting their release, that they might obtain a better resurrection'; widely recognized in commentary tradition as alluding to the 2 Maccabees 6-7 martyrdom narrative under Antiochus IV (Eleazar and the mother with seven sons); demonstrates the author of Hebrews engages Second Temple martyrology

Jude.1.14-15 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. Ἐνὼχ ἑβδομος ἀπὸ Ἀδάμ... ἰδοὺ ἦλθεν Κύριος ἐν ἁγίαις μυριάσιν αὐτοῦ (Henōch hebdomos apo Adam... idou ēlthen Kyrios en hagiáis myriásin autou)

Force. Jude quotes verbatim from 1 Enoch 1:9, a Second Temple Jewish apocalyptic text not in any Christian OT canon (Western or Eastern, except Ethiopian Orthodox); demonstrates NT authors can quote extra-canonical literature with approval without thereby canonizing it; the parallel to Paul quoting Aratus (Acts 17:28) and Epimenides (Titus 1:12) and Menander (1 Cor 15:33) is exact

Acts.17.28 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. ὥς καὶ τινες τῶν καθ' ὑμᾶς ποιητῶν εἰρήκασιν (hōs kai tines tōn kath' hymas poiētōn eirēkasin) G4163

Force. Paul quotes the pagan poet Aratus (Phaenomena 5) 'we are also his offspring' as supporting his Areopagus argument; the quotation is approving but the poet is not made Scripture; provides the controlling analogy for Jude's use of 1 Enoch and Hebrews' use of 2 Maccabees: NT authors can quote without canonizing

Matt.23.35 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. ἀπὸ τοῦ αἵματος Ἀβελ τοῦ δικαίου ἕως τοῦ αἵματος Ζαχαρίου (apo tou haimatos Habel tou dikaiou heōs tou haimatos Zachariou)

Force. Matthean parallel to Luke 11:51 with the same Genesis-to-Chronicles bracketing; the consistency between the two synoptic traditions establishes that Jesus' working canon scope ends with Chronicles in the Hebrew ordering, not with Maccabees in the Greek ordering

2Tim.3.16 · **neutral** · genre: epistle

Key term. πᾶσα γραφὴ θεόπνευστος (pasa graphē theopneustos) G1124/G2315

Force. θεόπνευστος ('God-breathed') is predicated of γραφή as a class; the question of which writings count as γραφή is left to other lexical and historical evidence; Paul does not enumerate the OT canon here, so 2 Tim 3:16 does not by itself settle inclusion or exclusion of the deuterocanonical books, but it does set up the category to which the canon question applies

Eccl.12.12 · **neutral** · genre: wisdom

Key term. עֵץ וְיֵא תַבְרָה מִיִּרְפָּס תוֹשָׁע (asot sefarim harbeh ein qetz) H6213/H5612

Force. 'Of making many books there is no end'; not a canon-formula but reflects the Hebrew Wisdom tradition's awareness of a closing of authoritative writing; cited in patristic and rabbinic discussion of canonical limits but not a direct deuterocanonical rejection

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1124, G3551, G4396, G5568, G3051, G129, G2315, G4163, G6, G2197, H6213, H5612

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Athanasius, Festal Letter 39 (367 AD) · **complicates** · **verified**

"there are other books besides these not indeed included in the Canon, but appointed by the Fathers to be read by those who newly join us... The Wisdom of Solomon, and the Wisdom of Sirach, and Esther, and Judith, and Tobit"

patristic · Jerome, Prologus Galeatus (Prologue to the Books of Samuel and Kings, c. 391 AD) · **affirms** · **verified**

"Whatever is outside these [22 Hebrew books] must be placed among the Apocrypha. Therefore Wisdom... Sirach, Judith, and Tobit are not in the canon."

patristic · Augustine, On Christian Doctrine 2.8 (c. 397 AD); confirmed at Council of Hippo 393 and Carthage 397 · **denies** · **verified**

"Augustine and the African councils list Tobit, Judith, 1-2 Maccabees, Wisdom, and Sirach among the divine Scriptures; this represents the broader Latin-African reception that Trent later canonized."

catholic_magisterial · Council of Trent, Session 4, Decree on the Canonical Scriptures (8 April 1546) · denies · verified

“Tobias, Judith, Wisdom, Ecclesiasticus, Baruch, two of the Maccabees received as sacred and canonical with equal piety and reverence; anathema on any who do not receive them as sacred and canonical.”

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church §120 (1992/1997) · denies · verified

“The Old Testament: Genesis... Tobit, Judith, Esther, 1 and 2 Maccabees... Wisdom, Sirach (Ecclesiasticus), Baruch... (46 books in the Old Testament canon)”

lutheran · Luther's German Bible (1534), Apocrypha section preface · complicates · verified

“These are books which are not held equal to the Holy Scriptures, and yet are useful and good to read.”

anglican · 39 Articles, Article VI (1571) · affirms · verified

“the other Books (as Hierome saith) the Church doth read for example of life and instruction of manners; but yet doth it not apply them to establish any doctrine”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 1.3 (1647) · affirms · verified

“The books commonly called Apocrypha, not being of divine inspiration, are no part of the canon of the Scripture, and therefore are of no authority in the Church of God.”

methodist · Methodist Articles of Religion, Article V (Wesley's 1784 abridgement of the 39 Articles) · affirms · verified

“Wesley omitted the Anglican Article 6 list of Apocryphal books that may be read; the Methodist 25 Articles affirm Scripture as containing all things necessary to salvation without granting the Apocrypha a recognized place”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession (1632), Article I; general Anabaptist usage following Luther's separation · affirms · verified

“Holy Scripture of the Old and New Testament alone as the only rule and standard of faith and life; Apocrypha not included in doctrinal Scripture for Anabaptist confessional usage”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 1 (1916, revised) · affirms · verified

“The Scriptures, both the Old and New Testaments, are verbally inspired of God and are the revelation of God to man, the infallible, authoritative rule of faith and conduct. (66-book Protestant canon assumed)”

eastern_orthodox · Synod of Jerusalem (1672), Confession of Dositheus, Decree 3; Orthodox Church in America catechetical materials · denies · verified

“Wisdom of Solomon, Judith, Tobit, History of the Dragon, History of Susanna, the Maccabees, and the Wisdom of Sirach. For we judge these also to be with the other genuine Books of Divine Scripture genuine parts of Scripture.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/luke/24-44.htm>

“ἐν τῷ νόμῳ Μωϋσέως καὶ τοῖς προφήταις καὶ ψαλμοῖς - 'in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and Psalms' (threefold Hebrew enumeration)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/luke/11-51.htm>

“ἀπὸ αἵματος Ἀβελ ἕως αἵματος Ζαχαρίου - 'from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah' (Genesis to 2 Chronicles in Hebrew ordering)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/3-2.htm>

“ἐπιστεύθησαν τὰ λόγια τοῦ Θεοῦ - 'they were entrusted with the oracles of God' (Jewish custody of the Hebrew Bible scope)”

supports · category: primary_repository · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/greek/1124.htm>

“γραφὴ (graphē) G1124: 51 NT occurrences; consistently denotes the Hebrew Bible plus emerging apostolic writings; no NT use applies graphē to deuterocanonical books”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/11-35.htm>

“ἐτυμπανίσθησαν, οὐ προσδεξάμενοι τὴν ἀπολύτρωσιν - 'were tortured, not accepting their release' (likely allusion to 2 Macc 6-7 martyrdom)”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/jude/1-14.htm>

“Jude 14-15 quotes 1 Enoch 1:9 verbatim; demonstrates NT engagement with Second Temple literature without canonization”

supports · category: patristic_archive · <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/2806039.htm>

“Athanasius Festal Letter 39: lists 22 OT books as canon; Wisdom, Sirach, Esther, Judith, Tobit 'not indeed included in the Canon, but appointed by the Fathers to be read'”

opposes · category: magisterial ·

https://www.vatican.va/content/catechism/en/part_one/section_one/chapter_two/article_3/iv_the_canon_of_scripture.html

“CCC §120: 46 OT books accepted as canonical, including Tobit, Judith, 1-2 Maccabees, Wisdom, Sirach, and Baruch alongside the protocanonical books”

nuance · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.churchofengland.org/prayer-and-worship/worship-texts-and-resources/book-common-prayer/articles-religion>

“39 Articles, Article VI: 'the Church doth read [the Apocrypha] for example of life and instruction of manners; but yet doth it not apply them to establish any doctrine’”

nuance · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org>

“Lutheran Book of Concord and Luther's German Bible: Apocrypha printed as separate appendix between OT and NT, 'useful and good to read' but 'not held equal to the Holy Scriptures’”

opposes · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-bible>

“Orthodox Church in America: includes deuterocanonical books (Anaginoskomena) as part of the OT; Synod of Jerusalem 1672 received them as genuine Scripture”

supports · category: patristic_archive · https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206/Page_487.html

“Jerome Prologus Galeatus: 'Whatever is outside these [22 Hebrew books] must be placed among the Apocrypha. Therefore Wisdom, Sirach, Judith, and Tobit are not in the canon.’”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/17-28.htm>

“Acts 17:28: Paul quotes pagan poet Aratus approvingly without canonizing him; controlling analogy for Heb 11:35 and Jude 14-15”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- apparatus-vs-counter-witness-conflict
- confession-tradition-divergence